

Savanna

Tropical regions of the world that are too dry for dense rainforest support open grasslands with scattered trees are known as savannas. In the tropical wet season, they are lush and green, but for half the year they are hot, dry, and scorched by wildfires.

WHERE IN THE WORLD?

Tropical grasslands form in warm regions near the equator that have long dry seasons. They include the African savannas, and similar grasslands in South America, India, and northern Australia.



AROUND THE WORLD

Many tropical grasslands are dry with just a few trees. Others are more thickly wooded, or become flooded by seasonal rains. Some have plants adapted for life on high mountains.



SHORTGRASS SAVANNA
The Serengeti in east Africa is a sea of grass dotted with trees.



WOODED SAVANNA
This savanna in Australia is more like open woodland.



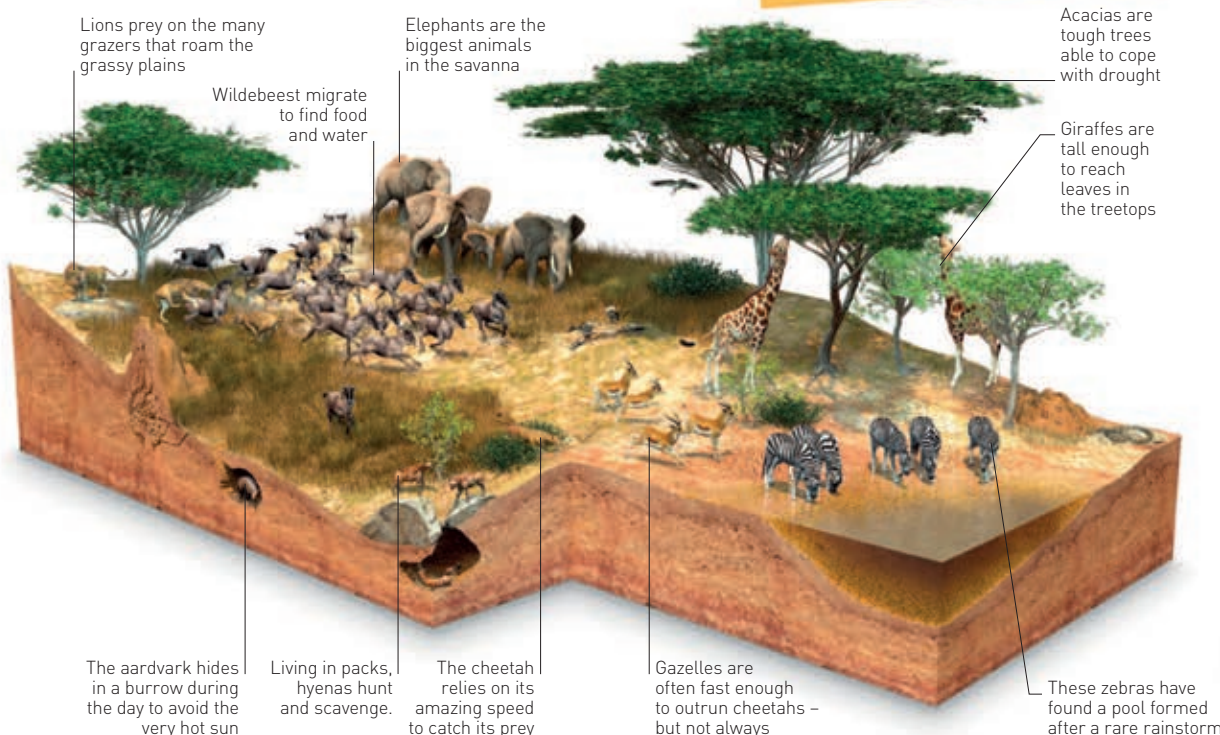
FLOODED SAVANNA
Much of the Llanos in South America floods in the rainy season.



MONTANE SAVANNA
Above the tree line it is cooler than in shortgrass savanna.

LIFE IN THE SAVANNA

The plants and animals of typical savannas are adapted to survive months without rain. Many of the plants are able to avoid losing too much moisture, and the animals learn where to find supplies of vital drinking water.



IN THE DRY SEASON, THE AFRICAN SAVANNA ONLY RECEIVES AROUND 10 CM (4 IN) OF RAIN

UNDER THREAT

The wild animals and plants of the savanna are threatened by poaching, habitat loss and fragmentation, farming, and climate change.

HUNTING

Illegal hunting of savanna animals such as elephants, rhinos, and gazelles is endangering some species. These animals will become extinct if it continues.

OVERGRAZING

Many farmers keep goats and cattle on the savanna. If there are too many animals, they eat all the wild plants, and the grassland will turn into a barren desert.

FARMING

More of the savanna is being turned into farmland. Almost half of the wild tropical grassland in South America is now planted with crops such as maize.

WATER LOSS

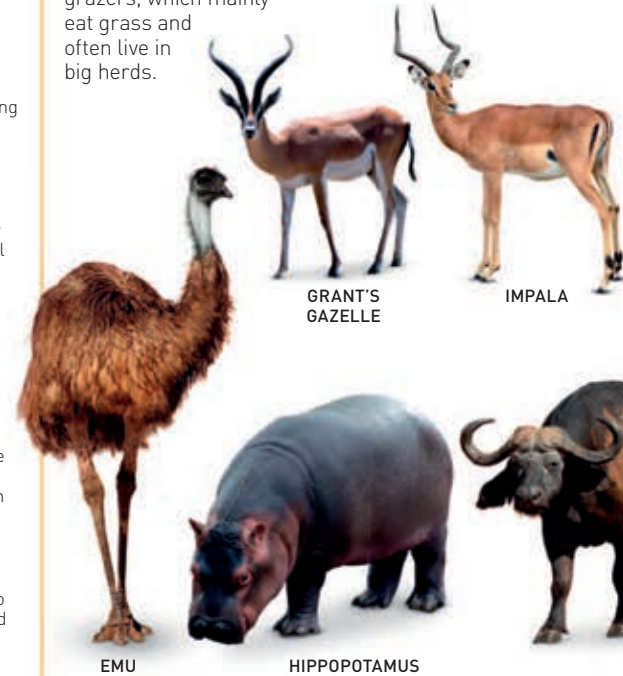
Farm crops need regular watering to survive the tropical dry season. The water is taken from natural sources, so there is not enough left for wild animals and plants.

CLIMATE CHANGE

Global climate change may result in more grasslands turning to desert. But it may also cause some rainforest regions to dry out and become savanna grasslands.

BROWSERS AND GRAZERS

The plant life of the savannas provides food for a wide variety of animals. Some are browsers, which gather the leaves of trees and bushes. Others are grazers, which mainly eat grass and often live in big herds.



EMU

HIPPOPOTAMUS

GRANT'S GAZELLE

IMPALA

HUNTERS AND SCAVENGERS

Powerful hunters such as lions prey on the big plant-eating animals. Others, including the giant anteater, hunt insects. Scavengers eat the remains of dead animals.



BLACK VULTURE



SERVAL

LION

REPTILES, AMPHIBIANS, AND INSECTS

The savanna grasslands swarm with insects such as flies, beetles, and termites. There are also many species of frogs, lizards, and snakes.



AFRICAN ROCK PYTHON



NILE MONITOR